



MINDFUL "HOW" SKILLS – EFFECTIVELY



WHAT IS "EFFECTIVELY"?

- **Acting Effectively is doing what works to achieve our goals.**
This means focusing on WHAT WORKS rather than what is "right" vs. "wrong" or "fair" vs. "unfair". Acting effectively is the opposite of "Cutting off your nose to spite your face". It means using skillful means to achieve our goals.

BENEFITS OF ACTING EFFECTIVELY – WHY DO IT?

- **Without the skill of EFFECTIVENESS, it is difficult to reach our goals, reduce suffering, or increase happiness.**
Being right or proving a point may feel good in the moment, but in the long run getting what we want in life is more satisfying.

i.e. "Yelling at the reservation clerk who says you do not have a reservation for a hotel room (when you know you called and made one) may make you feel good in the moment, but actually getting a hotel room (which may require effective skills) would be likely to make you feel even better."

EFFECTIVELY – HOW TO DO IT?

- **Know the Goal or Objective**
Not knowing what we want makes effectiveness hard. It can be very hard to know what we want when we are in emotion mind.

We can mistake being afraid of something with not wanting something, being angry at someone with not wanting to be close to the person and being ashamed of our own actions with not wanting to be around certain people.

- **Know and Respond to the Actual Situation**
To be effective, you need to understand and respond to the actual situation, not to what you think the situation SHOULD be.

i.e. Signs on the freeway tell people to drive in the right lane except to pass. People who tailgate slower drivers in the left lane, switch their lights off and on, or keep honking instead of passing from the right lane, are acting as if all people are willing to follow highway directions. Not all are!

i.e. A person wants a raise at work, but thinks the supervisor should know without being told. As a result, the person refuses to ask for it. In this case, the person is putting being right over achieving the goal of getting a raise.

- **Know What Will and Won't Work to Achieve Goals**

When in Wise Mind, we often know what is and what is not effective. To be effective, some people may need to improve their problem-solving skills or consider asking for help or for instructions in what to do.

Effectiveness requires there to be an openness to experimenting, to staying aware of the consequences of what we do, and sufficient humility to learn from our mistakes.

i.e. If you want people to remember your birthday, you can call to remind them beforehand, rather than letting them forget

i.e. When things are going wrong at the airport, it is more effective to talk calmly to the people who can help you than to yell at them. Yelling and making a scene can cause the reservations person to put you on a flight far in the future.

- **"Play by the Rules" When Necessary**

Playing by the rules is required in situations where what we want is important and we depend on the help of others.

i.e. Being an applicant for a bank loan, or a person going through security at the airport. In each situation, other people make the rules and can enforce them.

- **Be Savvy about People**

Effectiveness means being "political" or savvy about people. It is about recognizing where people are, rather than where they "should be" and going from there. Different people are like different cultures. What works in one culture may not work in another. Focusing on what is "RIGHT" instead of what works is like trying to impose our own culture on another country when visiting.

- **Sacrifice a Principle to Achieve a Goal when Necessary**

There are some situations where people are willing to sacrifice their principles in order to achieve their goal as a means to an end. This is especially hard in situations with people in positions of authority. For example, someone may have the goal of working at their company for the long term, however, their company has some practices that are not so environmentally friendly.

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Exercise 1: Effectively

KNOWING THE GOAL OR OBJECTIVE --- Can you think of a time when confusion over goals and objectives interfered with your effectiveness? ...or when emotions interfered? Did you ever confuse an emotion with what you really wanted? Please describe:

BEING SAVVY ABOUT PEOPLE --- Can you think of times when you imposed your views on others, or when others imposed their views on you? Please describe:

Can you think of a time when you acted with effectiveness to meet your goal(s) despite other urges or temptations? Please describe. What urge did you have and how did you get over it to choose a skillful, effective action?

Reflect on which "HOW" skill is your strength? Which is your weakness? (taking a nonjudgmental stance, focusing on one thing at a time, or being effective). *The skill you find the hardest is the one you need to practice most!*